PAUL TONDEN, MBA · DBA CANDIDATE

AI Adoption & Enablement · Leadership Development · Organizational Effectiveness

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Talent development executive who can both hold the room and build the system. Ten years leading enterprise leadership development, organizational effectiveness, and change initiatives inside a publicly traded education company, including five years in Corporate Human Resources under the Vice President of Talent. Now designing and delivering human-centered AI adoption for executive teams and running an operating company on agentic workflows built in-house. The combination is uncommon: most practitioners who can facilitate a room of skeptical executives have never built an agentic workflow, and most who have built one cannot facilitate the room.

SELECTED WORK IN AI ADOPTION

- **Human-Centered AI Leadership, Canon Financial Services (2025).** Designed and delivered an AI adoption program for the executive leadership team and full corporate staff, built for skeptics rather than early adopters: responsible-adoption culture, leadership self-assessment, and team dynamics. Facilitated Maxwell Leadership's The Leadership Game for the executive suite as a licensed facilitator.
- **AI-augmented operating model, Blue Moon Estate Sales Orlando West.** Designed and built agentic workflows running client settlement reporting, month-end financial reconciliation, cash-flow forecasting, CRM maintenance, and marketing production, enabling a lean founding team to operate with enterprise-grade rigor. Audited the system in 2026 against acted-upon output and reduced scheduled automation by 78 percent with no loss of value, a discipline most organizations skip.
- **Doctoral research, in progress.** Qualitative study of how mid- to senior-level leaders understand and enact human-centered values, including creativity, learning, and well-being, when integrating generative AI into the work.

CORE COMPETENCIES

AI Strategy & Responsible Adoption · AI-Augmented Operations & Agentic Workflows · Leadership Development Program Design · Executive Education & Facilitation · Organizational Development & Change Management · M&A Culture Integration · Design Thinking · Instructional Design & Adult Learning · Emotional Intelligence (HBDI, DiSC, EQ) · Talent Strategy & Succession · DEIB Strategy · P&L Ownership

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Paint It Black Design Group, LLC | Orlando, FL — 2023 – Present

Principal, Human-Centered Systems Design & Leadership Development

- Advise organizations on leadership development, strategic innovation, and AI adoption; design and deliver executive education and workshops, including the Canon Financial Services engagement above.
- Co-host and co-produce the Thought Partners Podcast on strategy, leadership, and human-centered design.

Praxis Studio, Inc. | Blue Moon Estate Sales Orlando West · Winter Garden, FL — 2025 – Present

Managing Director

- Direct a services business supporting families through senior relocation, estate settlement, and downsizing, with full accountability for P&L, hiring, marketing, sales, and client experience.
- Operate the business as a live case study in human-centered service design and AI-enabled operations, directly informing doctoral research and executive teaching.

Strategic Education, Inc. | Herndon, VA (hybrid) — 2020 – 2025

Senior Talent Development Consultant, Human Resources

- **Built and launched Elevate,** the company's first enterprise-wide leadership development program, from scratch. It did not exist before. Engaged 300+ people leaders across every business unit and was delivered internationally to cross-functional cohorts.
- **Selected to lead cross-institutional talent integration** through the Capella, Strayer, and Torrens University combinations, aligning leadership practice across three institutional cultures on two continents.
- **Founded and facilitated the company's first Leadership Community of Practice,** connecting approximately 700 US-based people leaders across all business units.

- **Led enterprise talent strategy through the COVID-19 pivot** to fully online operations and the subsequent design of the hybrid workplace model; operated hybrid throughout, working across 40+ campuses nationwide and corporate offices in Herndon, VA and Minneapolis, MN.
- **Co-chaired the CEO's Council on Diversity, Equity & Inclusion** and led the global annual HR compliance training program across the enterprise.
- **Delivered 500+ HBDI cognitive-profile debriefs** and certified DiSC and emotional intelligence programs integrated into enterprise talent strategy; emceed the SEI Annual Summit Executive Leadership Conference, 2023 to 2025.

Strayer University | Washington, D.C. 2015 – 2020
Director, Academic Insights & Operations

- Led the institutional interface between the university and its academic partners, supporting adjunct and academic teams in curriculum alignment, program development, and learning outcomes measurement.
- Led a team providing training and development for staff and faculty in communication, coaching, motivation, and creativity.

Godiva Chocolatier / Gymboree Corporation | Multi-state, East Coast 2009 – 2015
Multi-Unit, Multi-Brand District Manager

- Owned operations, talent development, merchandising, and P&L across geographically distributed retail portfolios. Won the CEO Award for District of the Year (2013) on double-digit year-over-year improvement across all metrics.

EDUCATION & DOCTORAL RESEARCH

Capella University Expected 2027
Doctor of Business Administration (DBA), Strategy & Innovation — Candidate

- Dissertation in progress: how mid- to senior-level leaders understand and enact human-centered values when integrating generative AI to support employee creativity, learning, and well-being. Qualitative inquiry, constructivist paradigm.

Jack Welch Management Institute, Strayer University 2018
Master of Business Administration (MBA), executive leadership focus

Rowan University
Bachelor of Arts · Former adjunct instructor, seven years

CERTIFICATIONS

Maxwell Leadership Certified Coach, Speaker & Trainer · HBDI® Certified Practitioner (Herrmann International) · Maxwell DISC Certified Consultant · LeadX Emotional Intelligence Certification · Host, Live2Lead Central Florida (Maxwell Leadership simulcast, 2026)